A Healthy Mind

How to Build an Unshakable Mind in a Noisy World



Omar Garagozov

A HEALTHY MIND

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Omar Garagozov

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“You have power over your mind,
not outside events. Realize this, and
you will find strength.”

— *Marcus Aurelius*

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How to Build an Unshakable Mind in a Noisy World

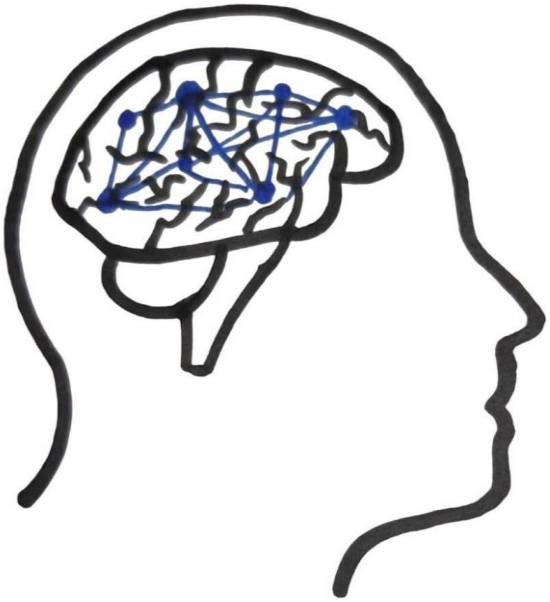
A Healthy Mind

Our minds are fascinating. The fact that we stand at the pinnacle of life on Earth is due to our human spirit, directed by our minds. Human history spans roughly 200,000 years, a mere 0.004% of our planet's 4.5-billion-year story. Yet, in that blink of geological time, we have transformed our world completely.

The engine behind this transformation is our capacity for change. We think and shape; we create and innovate; we listen and assist others; and most importantly, we rewire. This flexibility (our ability to learn, unlearn, and relearn) is why we have outpaced other mammals that have existed for millions of years prior to us.

Neuroscience calls this ability neuroplasticity, and it's more than an abstract concept. It is a physical reality: neurons form new connections, synapses strengthen with use, and entire brain networks reshape themselves based on our experiences and choices over time.

Unlike most animals, we have the unique capacity to intentionally direct this process.



This book is your handbook for doing exactly that—transforming your mental rhythms, handling demanding routines, and navigating life with greater clarity. But to work effectively with your mind, you must first understand what you're working with.

The human mind—that landscape of thoughts, self-awareness, and inner dialogue we take for granted—has not always existed in its current form. While the biological foundations of our brain emerged with *Homo sapiens*, the

way we experience consciousness has been profoundly shaped by language, culture, and historical upheaval.

Take a look at the the Axial Age (roughly 800–200 BCE), a period when human consciousness underwent a radical shift across continents. In Greece, Socrates urged citizens to “know thyself.” In India, the Upanishads explored the nature of inner experience. In China, Confucius emphasized moral introspection. For the first time in recorded history, humanity turned its focus inward, developing the reflective self-awareness that defines modern consciousness.

This journey continued through the medieval period, where the mind was viewed through a spiritual lens before the Renaissance and Enlightenment eras, when Descartes's “I think, therefore I am” solidified the modern concept of self. The Industrial Revolution facilitated major advances in psychology and neuroscience. Today, we live in an era of unprecedented self-awareness—sometimes to the point of anxiety.

Consciousness is elastic; it has evolved and continues to transform. The same neuroplasticity that allowed our ancestors to adapt from survival in small tribes to thriving in complex societies is available to you right now to move from where you are to where you want to be.

I turned to neuroscience research, experimenting with techniques to rewire my own patterns of focus, motivation,

and cognitive processes. What I found transformed how I approach every challenge today.

In this book, I share the principles that emerged from that process—pragmatic methods for improving focus, motivation, and resilience in demanding routines.

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YOU ARE WHAT
YOU CONSUME

You are What You Consume

In 2004, two psychologists at the University of Hawaii, Elaine Hatfield and Richard Rapson, pulled 48 complete strangers off campus and paired them into same gender duos. The instructions were almost insultingly simple: sit together for 15 minutes, seven times over seven weeks, and talk about anything you like—no scripts, tasks, or prizes. Before the first meeting and again after the last, each student filled out two quick personality sheets: one that maps how upbeat or irritable you feel (the PANAS mood scale), another that sketches the Big Five contours of your character.

When the researchers compared the “before” and “after” fingerprints, they found something quite interesting—each person had become more like the other: positive-affect scores had migrated 32% closer to the partner’s, negative-affect scores 27% closer, and even traits such as extraversion and agreeableness had quietly converged—all inside fourteen total hours of conversation. The closer the two people sat, and the longer they held eye contact, the faster the sync, suggesting that mimicry of micro-expressions—not the words—was the carrier signal.

We now live in an environment of constant exposure. Every piece of data can be found online; therefore, you

should be aware of what you consume—and what you repeatedly attend to. Glance at what you are exposed to every single day and every single hour of it, then ponder: does it actually suit me? Do I really like this?

If you are mindful and ready for change, you will adjust your feed—receiving cleaner suggestions online and, overall, reducing your screen time. You will realize that what you repeatedly see and feel compelled to do gradually becomes part of who you are.

The experiment you just read about supports this idea—if you consistently surround yourself with disciplined, focused people, your own behaviors are likely to shift in that direction; the same applies to less constructive environments. Therefore, not only your digital feed, but also your social surroundings are what you will transform into.

Now, by this, I mean that you should be willing to change. You should be mindful of what you are feeding your mind. Every piece of data counts.

How to change?

+ Not Interested:

Transforming fully might be too extreme for a person, for this reason, you should change in small steps. If you have some time-wasting videos on your feed, you must press

“not interested” and go on—as this keeps you from becoming yourself and which may contribute to cognitive overload (often mistaken for burnout). These videos move like a chain—they keep you from reaching your potential and make you sad when you realize that you can escape, but you are too lazy to do so.

+ Deduction:

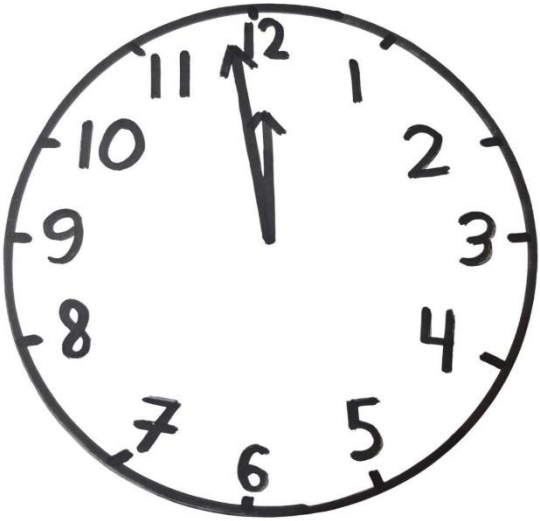
Reduce your screen time. Reduce your screen duration. This affects your reward system and attention patterns over time. People think that if society has normalized it, then there are no setbacks; if your goal is meaningful change, reducing screen time becomes vital. Reducing your screen time can help you to be consistently bored—and this is what we are trying to achieve to get to the next step.

+ Tedium:

Now, when you are in a bored state, your first three to five thoughts will probably be to return to your phone and do whatever you feel like doing. These thoughts are low-effort escapes, which will hold you back from accomplishing your tasks. Maybe you would want to get a snack: remember, this is also a temptation.

After these thoughts (specifically, after a short period of discomfort), you will have better ones. Instead of reaching for your phone, you might suddenly think: “I should outline that essay” or “I could go for a walk.” These aren't

distractions but rather signals. As your attention refocuses, act on at least one of these thoughts. It is this simple; however, taking action is the demanding part.



These steps may seem simple, but they form the foundation of lasting behavioral change.

Master these, and the rest becomes significantly easier—as these will help you realize yourself.

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THE PURIFICATION PROCESS

The Purification Process

Now, Bob wanted to get himself in shape. Bob bought a gym membership and worked out every single day, but after four months, he didn't see any results. He thought that his body had a problem—and he was actually right. For those four months, he ate fast food every single day too. Just like always.

Now, you may have similar problems as Bob. Your junk food might not be food—but it is something you still feed on. And it is holding you down.

The solution is not what most people think. It's not about adding more discipline or working harder. It's about removal—a principle that's been understood for centuries but forgotten in modern self-improvement culture.

The Historical Background

Let's delve deeper: In medieval times, transformation was never understood as an act of accumulation. To become greater was not to add, but to purify. The belief was that all excellence—spiritual, intellectual, or physical—began with removal. This principle was known not only in monasteries and churches, but also in workshops, training yards, and the inner philosophy of the era.

Medieval thinkers saw excess as weight. The soul, like the body, could become burdened. Comfort dulled discipline. Indulgence weakened resolve. A man who consumed without restraint was believed to lose mastery over himself, and without mastery, no greatness could be sustained. Thus, purification was the first law of ascent.

Monastic life embodied this truth most clearly. Before a monk could approach God, he underwent fasting, silence, and deprivation. Food was reduced, sleep was shortened. This was not done as punishment, but as preparation. Hunger sharpened awareness. Simplicity strengthened focus. By denying the body its excesses, the monk trained his will, learning to command desire rather than be ruled by it. A weak will, medieval writers warned, could never carry a strong purpose.

The same belief appeared in medieval alchemy. Alchemists held that base matter could not be elevated without first being broken down. The early stages of transformation were always destructive: burning away impurities, dissolving hardened forms, and separating what was corrupt from what was essential. Gold could not be created by addition—it emerged only after reduction. This process mirrored the transformation of the self.

What was impure had to be removed before what was noble could remain. This approach is what will help you achieve your goals—but much faster.

The Scientific Explanation

The brain pursues goals through two opposing functions: activating what matters and suppressing what does not. This suppression is not free. It consumes attention, energy, and cognitive bandwidth. When destructive habits coexist with productive aims, the mind is forced into constant background resistance. Progress slows not because of a lack of willpower, but because willpower is being spent simply to hold competing impulses down.

Remove the destructive element, and the equation changes. The need for suppression diminishes. Mental resources are no longer diverted toward restraint and can be fully applied to execution. Efficiency increases not by trying harder, but by carrying less.

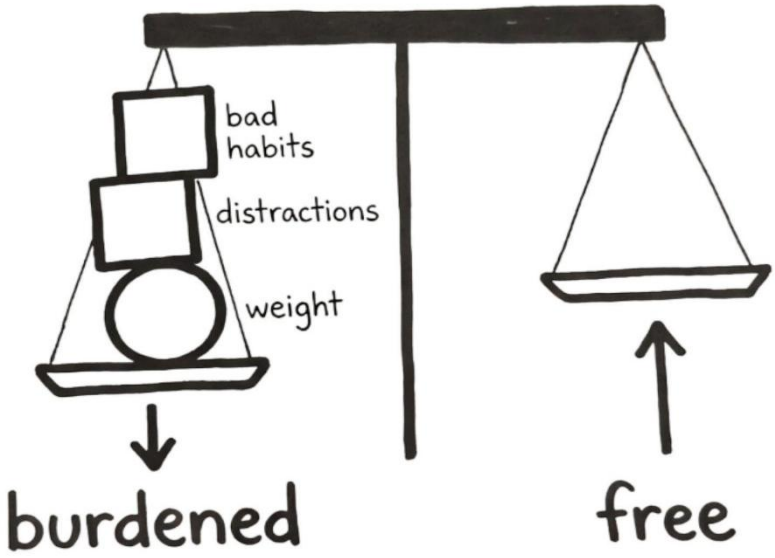
This principle appears in modern behavioral research. Studies on problem-solving show that people instinctively try to add rather than remove, even when subtraction may contribute to faster, cleaner solutions. When participants are encouraged to consider removal, performance improves and cognitive effort decreases. The mind works harder to resist subtraction than to benefit from it. Once

removal is chosen, action becomes smoother and more direct.

The implication is simple: many struggles are self-inflicted. Energy is wasted maintaining what should have been cut. Bad habits, unnecessary commitments, excess input, do not merely coexist with the mission; they actively tax it. They require continuous management, continuous restraint, and continuous negotiation.

Purification is not deprivation for its own sake. It is a strategic elimination. By removing what drains attention and weakens focus, you reduce internal resistance. The path forward narrows, and movement accelerates.

You do not rise by adding more strength—you rise by removing what keeps pulling you down.



How to Discard Your Obstacles

Purification fails when you treat it like a mood instead of a method. You don't need to feel inspired. You need to be specific about what gets removed. The target is anything that creates ongoing drag on execution, and that means looking at behavior instead of intentions. Plans don't matter.

Start by identifying where you consistently stall. Look for the moments, places, or inputs that force you to fight yourself. Anything that needs constant resistance is already

taxing you. These are your targets. They cost you whether you win the fight or not.

Once you see them, don't rely on willpower. That keeps the problem alive. Restructure so the behavior can't happen easily. Move to a different room. Change the schedule. Remove access.

Shift the default. When the environment stops supporting the obstacle, execution stops being a struggle.

Next, cut the inputs that scatter your attention. Information and stimulation feel productive but often aren't. If it doesn't directly serve the objective, it competes with it. Narrow what you let in. Reactions are cheap. Action requires protected focus.

Commitments work the same way. Every obligation carries weight even when you're not working on it. Open loops and vague promises split attention. Drop what doesn't serve the main thing. Speed comes from depth, not breadth.

Internal obstacles survive longer than external ones. Beliefs like needing pressure, thriving in chaos, or lacking discipline. These stories need maintenance. They protect comfort. Stop telling them. No replacement necessary; Act, and let results build the new identity.

Finally, keep checking. New resistance appears as you grow. What helped before may slow you now. Review habits, inputs, commitments. Purification repeats.

Done right, this simplifies execution. Focus stabilizes. Efficiency rises without more effort. Remove the drain, and the system operates with greater efficiency.

A Healthy Mind

THE JOURNALING PROCESS

The Journaling Process

Now, Bob thought that it would be a great idea to acquire a journaling book. He bought it, and as soon as he bought it he got excited and got into the process. He wrote there, checked in everyday, writing long and abstract texts regarding his thoughts. It felt like it was a stream of consciousness.

After a week of writing pages of unfiltered thought paragraphs, he started to write every 3 days only and thought it was having the same effect as writing every day.

After the 2nd week, he forgot about his newly formed habit of journaling. He thought it was boring and time-wasting instead of meaningful and productive.

But why did he actually let this change happen? Matter of fact, why did this shift in his mindset toward this activity happen?

What Would Happen if Bob Didn't Quit?

Bob would be completely different if he continued to journal. According to neuroimaging research from UCLA, his prefrontal cortex would strengthen, and the amygdala would be calmed by up to 30%. This gives no space for

anxiety and strengthens emotional control. Moreover, according to research published in *Social Cognitive and Affective Neuroscience*, regular, reflective writing increases grey matter density in the hippocampus, the brain region responsible for memory consolidation. After mentioning all of these benefits, we can see that Bob abandoned much more than just improvement—he abandoned intelligence and calmness, spitting on his own potential.

How to Journal—So That You Don't End up Like Bob

A lot of people, as I have seen, start journaling by just writing their mind off on a notebook or their phone—and I believe that this is the primary reason why they actually quit this habit. They think it's pointless and ridiculous. But the main reason is that they think they can put in low effort and get a great benefit. This is the main reason for how numerous practices are being abandoned. Journaling, as any other activity, requires full focus. Every single action requires focus and planning, and this habit is no less than them. However, I don't mean that you should work as hard as possible when it comes to journaling, but you need to have a certain plan.

The Five Layers

Journaling is the structured organization of thought.

Unstructured writing fails as cognitive engineering because it allows contradictions avoiding critical thinking. The page becomes a kind of messy mirror rather than a workshop. Without structure, thoughts cannot be analyzed or improved in any way.

Effective journaling requires multiple forms for different functions. Reflection demands different architecture than planning; emotional processing requires different scaffolding than decision analysis. A single method cannot address the full range of cognitive needs. The system must include distinct frameworks: one for decompressing chaotic experience, another for compressing complex decisions, others for tracking patterns and building foresight.

Your mind is not a single room. It is a house with different floors, each built for different work. You do not cook in the bedroom. You do not sleep in the kitchen. Yet most people journal as if one blank page can handle every kind of mental labor—panic and planning, wound-cleaning and world-building, all dumped into the same undifferentiated space. The result is mind clutter, not clarity.



The system comprises five layers:

+ Decompression Layer:

This is the pressure valve for mental dump and stress offloading. When your mind is crowded with circulating thoughts that refuse to settle, this layer relocates them to external storage. It does not analyze nor solve the problem—it simply clears the cache so the system can breathe again.

+ Organization Layer:

Once the pressure drops, pattern recognition becomes possible. This layer handles error correction, learning extraction, meaning compression. It transforms raw experience into inspectable data. Here you ask: What actually happened? What did I miss? What repeats?

- **Construction Layer:**

With clarity established, you build forward. Planning, decision modeling, discipline building. This layer assembles cognitive scaffolding for a future that does not yet exist. It is the thing which converts intention into architecture.

- **Direction Layer:**

Construction without navigation drifts, and this layer maintains goal alignment, priority calibration, and strategic review. It is the compass function—ensuring that what you are building does point where you actually want to go.

- **Identity Layer:**

The foundation beneath all of the others. Self-concept construction and character training. This layer answers: Who must I become to hold what I am building? Without it, the structure stands on nothing.

Each layer addresses a different stage of cognitive processing. Decompression handles input overload and the organization extracts signals from noise. All of this while construction builds forward pathways. Direction maintains

course correction with identity anchoring the entire system to a coherent self-model.

The frameworks are sequential in application but continuous in operation. A mind under pressure cannot organize. A mind without organization cannot construct. A mind without construction drifts. A mind adrift cannot become.

+ Layer 1 decompression

Before clarity, there must be space. Before structure, there must be relief. A system under pressure cannot reorganize itself, and this is where journaling begins—not with insight, but with evacuation.

Decompression performs one operation: it reduces volume. The mind under stress is a crowded room where every thought demands attention simultaneously. Working memory overloads. The prefrontal cortex—responsible for analysis, decision, and control—surrenders resources to the limbic system, which knows only threat response.

Decompression reverses this. By externalizing the crowd, it restores neural bandwidth. The thoughts still exist, but no longer occupy working memory.

Decompression comes first because it is the gateway condition. No subsequent layer functions under load. You cannot recognize patterns while loops are running. You

cannot plan while anxious. You cannot direct while disoriented. Decompression is not preliminary work—it is a foundational infrastructure.

Decompression writing operates through three structural rules: No editing. The hand moves faster than the critic. No structure. Paragraphs, lists, fragments—form does not matter. No conclusion. The entry ends when pressure drops, not when meaning arrives.

The product is not for reading. It is for leaving behind.

+ Layer 2 organization

Decompression creates space. Organization gives that space structure. Once pressure is removed, the mind can begin sorting rather than reacting. This is where journaling becomes analysis and not release.

Organization converts raw experience into patterns. The decompressed mind now faces material that is external but undigested—scattered observations, disconnected reactions, events without context. It asks: What category does this belong to? What preceded it? What resulted? The function is signal extraction: separating noise from information, coincidence from causality, impulse from insight.

Without organization, decompression becomes hoarding. The evacuated material piles up in external storage: Pages

filled but unprocessed, thoughts relocated but untransformed. The journal becomes a landfill, not a laboratory. The mind gains temporary relief but builds no immunity. The same patterns repeat, the same errors recur, because nothing was extracted from the record. Experience accumulates without compounding into wisdom.

Organization writing operates through retrospective structure: fixed intervals (daily, weekly), categorical review (decisions, interactions, emotional states), and comparative analysis (expectation vs. outcome, previous period vs. current). The entry has form: sections, metrics, questions. The product is for pattern recognition across time. The journal becomes a dataset, and the self becomes its own subject.

+ Layer 3 construction

Organization reveals patterns. Construction turns them into systems. Clarity without construction produces awareness without change. This layer translates understanding into architecture.

Construction builds futures. It converts analysis into scaffolding, insight into infrastructure, intention into executable design. Where Organization asks what happened, Construction asks what next. It operates through decision modeling—simulating paths before

commitment, stress-testing choices against constraints, building mental prototypes of realities that do not yet exist.

The mechanism is proceduralization, during which the facts and data you consume transform into unconscious practices. Abstract understanding ("I should exercise") becomes concrete protocol ("Monday, Wednesday, Friday, 6:30 AM, gym bag prepared the night before"). This translation reduces decision fatigue by eliminating choice points. Willpower is conserved for execution, not spent on deliberation. Construction also creates commitment devices—structures that bind future self to present intention. The journal entry becomes a contract. The written plan becomes default.

Without Construction, Organization produces paralysis. The mind sees patterns but builds nothing. Insight accumulates without implementation. The journal becomes a museum of unacted wisdom—beautiful diagnoses, but no treatment. Or worse: construction attempts begin on unstable ground, plans built from contaminated analysis, structures that collapse under contact with reality because they were never stress-tested on paper first.

Construction writing operates through specification: defined objectives, broken into components, sequenced into phases, assigned to time. It uses implementation

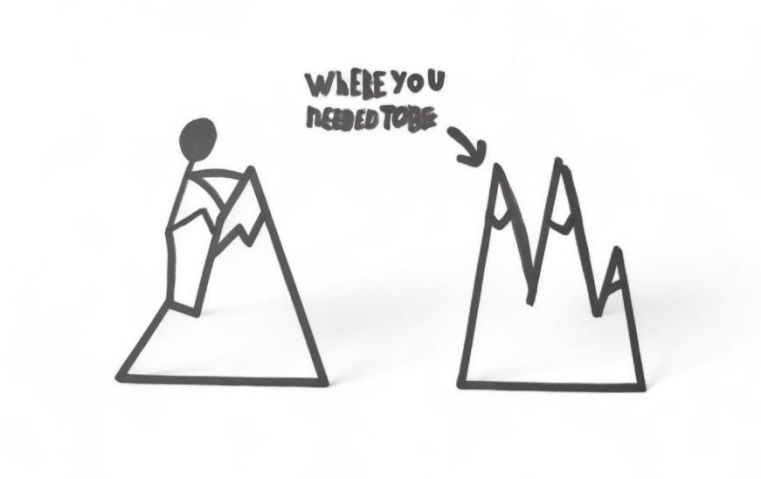
intentions—if then protocols that pre-decide responses to anticipated obstacles. The entry has engineering discipline: measurable outcomes, resource allocation, failure contingencies. The product is for execution. The journal becomes a blueprint. The self becomes a builder.

+ Layer 4 direction

Construction builds motion. Direction gives it meaning. Structure without direction produces movement without purpose. This layer is not planning—it is orientation.

Direction maintains strategic coherence. It calibrates trajectory, verifies alignment, preserves goal integrity over time. Where Construction asked how, Direction asks why, still. It audits the relationship between current action and original intention. That priority has not quietly inverted.

Without Direction, Construction produces productive distraction. The system executes excellently on goals that no longer matter. Discipline becomes rigidity and scaffolding becomes a cage. The journal documents impressive consistency while life quietly misaligns—you are climbing the wrong mountain, or climbing correctly toward a peak that is no longer worth reaching.



Or, maybe, the direction is attempted too early—before Construction—producing aspirational declarations without executable foundation: purpose without path, vision without vehicle.

Direction writing operates through interval audit: periodic review (weekly, monthly, quarterly) against established benchmarks. It uses hierarchical calibration: checking daily action against weekly objective, weekly against monthly, monthly against annual, annual against life. The entry has interrogative structure: What am I actually pursuing? What has changed? What persists? What should stop? The product is for decision. The journal becomes a map. The self becomes a navigator.

+ Layer 5 identity

Every system rests on a foundation. Identity is the foundation beneath all others. And without it, structure collapses into performance. This layer stabilizes the self who builds.

Identity constructs the self-model—the internal architecture of who you are, who you are becoming, and who you refuse to be. It is not a goal or plan or habit. It is the continuity layer: the stable reference point that persists when goals shift, plans fail, and habits break. Construction builds the machine. Identity builds the operator.

Without Identity, the system decays. Goals fragment because no stable self holds them. Discipline collapses because willpower exhausts. Direction drifts because no core navigates you. Construction produces hollow achievement—structures inhabited by no one coherent. The journal becomes productivity theater: optimized systems serving an undefined master, performance without presence, motion without meaning.

Decompression shows what pressures you. Organization shows what patterns define you. Construction shows what you can build. Direction shows where you point. Identity integrates these into self-knowledge: the stable platform

from which all future building proceeds. It answers: Who must I become to hold what I am constructing?

Identity writing operates through principle extraction and character specification: defining nonnegotiable standards, articulating the self-one is training into existence, reviewing decisions against declared identity rather than merely against outcomes.

+ System Integration

A system is defined by the cooperation of its parts. The layers do not operate independently. They form a continuous cognitive loop.

Decompression feeds Organization, enabling Construction, which requires Direction that stabilizes Identity—which orients future Decompression. The loop closes. The self who begins the next cycle is not the self who began the last.

Different pressures activate different layers. Acute overwhelm triggers Decompression exclusively—attempting Organization while flooded produces vague data. Execution failure signals Construction breakdown—plans exist but lack structural integrity. Drift and doubt reveal Direction gaps—motion continues but meaning decays.

A complete cognitive cycle moves from input to integration: external event → internal pressure → decompressed evacuation → organized analysis → constructed response → directed alignment → identity absorption → modified self-model → altered response to next event.

+ The Organized Flow

Architecture becomes power only when it becomes routine. A system is only real if it can be lived. The following is how a human being actually operates this system across time, energy states, and pressure conditions.

Reality looks like this: every morning, two minutes. What is important today, what needs safeguarding, what is threatening to blow away. Every night, five to seven minutes. If it was a heavy day, throw it away. If it was a light day, file away. Weekend, fifteen minutes to reflect on what patterns showed up and what needs an action plan. Once a month, thirty minutes to assess if what you are working towards is still aligned with where you plan to be.

Some days you can do the whole thing. When stressed dangerously, just decompress—write till your loop is broken. If even a readable entry is impossible, don't write at all. Under moderate stress, dump then write three sentences of pattern recognition. When low on energy,

condense all to one question: what is taking up space in the moment? Answer.

In an extreme state, write till your hand can no longer move. Don't create structure. Don't edit. Destroy the entry after if you like.

The principle is simple: match the layer to the condition, never demand the full system when part of it is enough. The system lives in flexibility, not rigidity.

+ System on Minimum

The system survives not by sophistication, but by sustainability.

Decompression and Organization merge. Write what presses, then immediately ask: What pattern is here? One paragraph of release. One sentence of recognition. Construction and Direction merge. Ask: What is the smallest next action? Write it. Identity is implicit—present in the choice of what to release, what to notice, what to do.

Morning or evening. Same time, anchored to existing habit—coffee, commuting, closing the laptop. Three components:

- **Clear** (2 minutes): Unload what occupies. No editing and no structure.

- **See** (2 minutes): One pattern, one insight, and one repetition noted.

- **Step** (1 minute): One action, defined specifically, assigned to time.

One notebook. One pen. Same location. No digital options—friction of opening, loading, choosing app becomes failure point. No prompts required. Only the three questions: What presses? What repeats? What next? The system runs on curiosity, not discipline. It sustains because it demands little. It works because it exists.

The Minimal System is not a reduced Advanced System. It is a complete system at a smaller scale. The full architecture remains available if pressure demands, energy permits, or need arises. But the foundation holds: clear, see, step. Five minutes. Every day.

+ The Self as a System

Your mind is not a given. It is an environment that tends toward turbulence without intervention. Thoughts circulate, accumulate, collide, and experience enters as raw input:

unmanaged, unfiltered, unprocessed. Without structure, this input becomes chaos. But with it, chaos becomes a matter.

This is what the system offers; not productivity, not optimization, and not even clarity but rather containment. A boundary. A place where the unmanageable can be placed, where the overwhelming can be held, where the self can meet its own contents without being submerged by them.

Writing is the oldest technology of self-regulation. The page holds what the mind can forget. And, in that holding, something shifts. The thought that circulates becomes the word that rests while the feeling that floods becomes the sentence that can be read. The self that is immersed becomes the self that observes.

You are not expressing yourself. You are organizing yourself. You are not writing thoughts—you are building a mind that can hold them. The journal is not a record but rather an architecture for consciousness—scaffolding for a self that persists, that learns, that chooses, and that continues.

The system is not the point but rather the method. The point, on the other hand, is consistency: waking tomorrow as someone who recognizes today, building year over year toward coherence, becoming the author of a self that holds it all together when pressure arrives.

This is why it matters. Not because journaling is virtuous but because governance and security of mind is necessary.

Because without it, we are only weather. Because with it, we become an environment—structured, stable, capable of holding what life sends, and of sending something back.

A Healthy Mind

MINDFULNESS MEDITATION

Mindfulness Meditation

Well, from the name of this chapter, you might already have some idea of what I'll be talking about. You may think, *"Oh, it's just mindfulness, I know what that is,"* but you actually don't. The reason is simple: most people think mindfulness is the same thing as meditation, but it simply isn't. Meditation is something you schedule—a specific activity, like a hobby; whereas mindfulness, on the other hand, is a state of self-awareness that helps you function better overall.

Imagine this: Bob needs to go to a nearby mall to buy some new clothes. While Bob is getting ready, he starts thinking, *"What will everyone think when they see me?"*. More thoughts pile up in Bob's head, and in the end, Bob doesn't even make it to the mall. Why? Because Bob wasn't being mindful. Bob wasn't acting with mindful awareness. He focused on other people's opinions when he should have been thinking about something simple, like what color of shirt he wants. That natural shift in his mind is a sign that he was not in a mindful state—Bob wasn't truly self-aware.

If Bob had taken just one minute to practice mindfulness before leaving, he would already be in the store, buying a new, fancy shirt. You might be wondering how to actually

do mindfulness, and in this chapter, I'll cover everything I've learned over the past three years of practicing it.

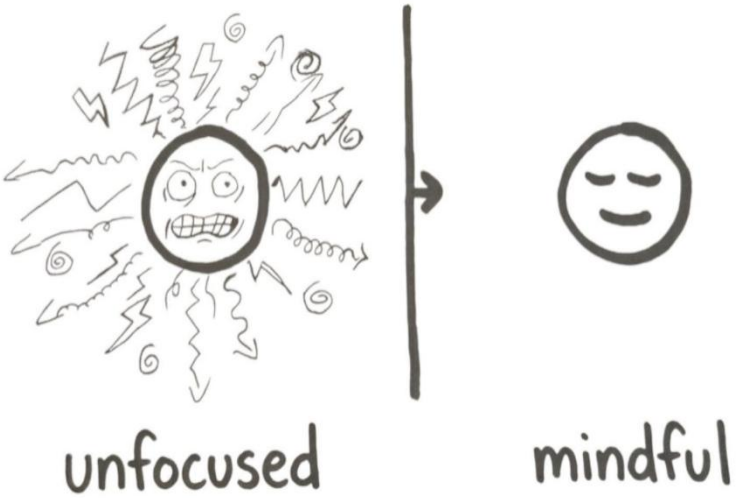
Mindfulness in a Neural Nutshell

The practice of mindfulness works in your favor—notably when it comes to your mind and overall brain health.

Researchers from the Universities of Southampton and Bath conducted a study involving 1,247 adults, most of whom had no prior experience with mindfulness. Each participant completed a one-month mindfulness program. By the end of the month, they saw a 12.6% decrease in anxiety, a 6.9% improvement in wellbeing, and a 6.5% increase in personal motivation to look after themselves. These are powerful results, especially for individuals who had never practiced mindfulness before.

From a biological perspective, mindfulness meditation increases grey-matter density in the prefrontal cortex, the area responsible for clear thinking, planning, and communication. It also reduces impulsivity, meaning you become less likely to act without thinking. Mindfulness helps the amygdala—the brain's key processor for emotions—remain calmer and less reactive to small

stressors, such as someone accidentally stepping on your shoe.



In addition, mindfulness enhances the brain's ability to form new neural connections, supporting better adaptability and resilience during stress.

My Change

The practice of mindfulness changed me for the better; I became more placid and stopped overreacting to any disturbance. Instead, my brain instinctively started to shift toward finding solutions and calming the situation. Out of all the benefits mindfulness gave me, this one is the biggest

change in my character, because I used to be very, very overreactive when I was younger, and that over reactivity made it hard for me to make friends.

Mindfulness for Beginners: Start Simple, Then Skyrocket.

Mindfulness can feel challenging at first. It requires your full attention, so avoid multitasking during the practice—trying to do two things at once often leads to doing both poorly. Instead, choose a quiet, calm space where you can focus fully on the activity. Close your eyes, settle into stillness, and allow your thoughts to flow. When your mind begins to wander or overthink, gently return to your breath. A slow, deep inhale can help reset your focus.

I recommend practicing mindfulness in the morning, or right before bed if you struggle with sleep, as it can calm and relax the mind. You can practice mindfulness almost anywhere and at any time, but avoid doing it in noisy environments or while eating. Practicing in these types of environments will only be counted as time wasted.

If you're a beginner, don't start with more than five minutes. Begin with 2–3 minutes and gradually increase the duration. For the first two weeks, add one minute per week. After that, if you want to deepen your practice and cultivate greater peace and resilience, increase your time by two minutes per week for the following four weeks.

After this period, adjust the duration to whatever feels right for you.

You can also practice mindfulness multiple times a day. Short, frequent sessions can be especially effective, and for me, personally, this is the best way to bring more clarity, calmness, and presence into daily life.

Incorporation into daily life

As we talked about earlier, mindfulness is most effective—at least for me—when practiced multiple times throughout the day. But one thing we haven't discussed is clearly when to do it.

The most important times to apply mindfulness are during paramount moments in your life. For example, before a job interview, a presentation, or even going to a social event with friends. Practicing mindfulness right before these experiences helps you maintain emotional clarity and prevents what I call "emotional burnout" during the activity.

You should also practice mindfulness during less intense but still meaningful moments— like going for a walk, commuting, or starting your everyday job tasks. These situations may not be emotionally heavy, but adding a small dose of mindfulness makes you more mentally prepared and emotionally stable throughout the day.

This doesn’t mean you need to practice before every single breath. The point is to integrate mindfulness regularly without going to extremes. Aim for four to five short sessions a day, even if you're a beginner. These brief practices help you develop more organized, calm, and intentional thoughts.

Last Thing

To summarize the whole chapter, here are the key points we learnt about mindfulness: Start small—begin with 2–3 minutes a day and increase the duration gradually; Use timing wisely— practice after waking up to boost focus, and before sleep to help the mind rest fully; Avoid poor environments—don’t practice while eating or in loud, distracting places, as it will not benefit you in any way; Be consistent—practice several times throughout the day for the best results; and lastly, use it when it matters most—especially before emotionally challenging moments, but also before ordinary tasks when needed. Just be careful not to overdo it.

These points explain how to practice mindfulness, but there is in fact much more. Even after this chapter, there is much more to learn—more ideas that define you as you, more tools that transform you as a human, and more ways to evolve while reading this book.

A Healthy Mind

DO YOUR CHEMISTRY

Do Your Chemistry

Chemistry was always harsh on me. I aced every exam in my final year of middle school— except chemistry. I studied three to four hours a day, trying to memorize formulas, but they always seemed faster than me. Everyone else understood it with ease, while I struggled.

That's why I became so frustrated. Every day, people saw me studying chemistry, spending nearly all my time on mastering it, yet I still couldn't score above a 90. Eventually, I bought a 300-page chemistry encyclopedia that explored the origins of chemistry and the early theories proposed by scientists. I lacked the motivation to study, as I was completely lost after multiple failed chemistry tests; nonetheless, I continued.

Over the course of two months, my grade jumped from 41% to 92%, making me the top student in my class. The progress wasn't instant, but during those two months I learned the philosophy behind the subject I feared most. At first, I opened that book reluctantly, but at the end, I became a brighter person, someone who finally understood what once was impossible.

From that experience, I became drawn to doing things that were genuinely hard—things so extreme that just thinking

about them made me uncomfortable. That discomfort offered me a rare glimpse into my own soul, and once I felt it, I wanted to experience it again. It taught me that harsh tasks, even those we instinctively resist, often carry the greatest rewards. What appears punishing from the outside can become, from within, a powerful catalyst for growth. For that reason, I believe that doing an extreme task every day— deliberately and mindfully—is one of the most meaningful acts a person can make in life.

People should understand that hard, extreme things aren't actually harsh—they are just challenging to comprehend. Your mindset is the thing that holds you back from accomplishing something astonishing and difficult. You might think that staying in your comfort zone is normal because everyone seems to live the same way: going to work or school and then wasting time on unimportant, dopamine-spiking tasks.

You need to get out of this. This lifestyle doesn't belong to you. You are meant for greater, more purposeful things—not for lying around and saying that you are no less than ordinary. We tend to choose the most comfortable tasks, not the ones that can make the greatest impact.

An ordinary lifestyle should be better than today's version of ordinary. I don't mean that you should run 60 km; I mean that you should walk 15 km—at least better than sitting all day eating chips while watching YouTube videos.

God wills us to be better, and not only God— we also have a natural desire to become better individuals in every way. That is why a person should strive to improve in anything their heart truly desires.

The Brain under Difficulty

Your brain, when you consistently tackle hard tasks every day, undergoes significant adaptations through a process called neuroplasticity. This is the brain's ability to reorganize itself by forming new neural connections and strengthening existing ones in response to repeated challenges. Essentially, your brain treats these daily efforts as training, leading to improved resilience, better emotional regulation, and enhanced cognitive function over time.

This transformation is clearly shown in my own experience with chemistry. When I first opened that thick encyclopedia, it wasn’t just hard—it felt like being roasted over a campfire, with every page bringing frustration and confusion as I forced myself to keep going despite wanting to quit. Over time, something changed: the material became easier and more familiar, until understanding ideas that once felt impossible became almost automatic, like breathing. My brain began to grasp the deeper logic of the subject, grouping large amounts of information into meaningful patterns instead of scattered facts that had overwhelmed me before. What started as intense

discomfort turned into real mastery, showing neuroplasticity in its simplest form— the brain's ability to adapt to challenges by reshaping itself and making learning easier over time.



Neuroplasticity is the reason we ended up in this position rather than primates or other species. It is why we live in a state-of-the-art world and why we have a greater advantage compared to other animals in the animal kingdom. The process of neuroplasticity in humans differs from that in animals—and it differs greatly.

The term "neural plasticity" (what we now commonly call neuroplasticity) was first introduced by the Polish

neuroscientist Jerzy Konorski in 1948, building on earlier ideas about how the brain could change. Later experiments expanded on this concept, but we don't need to dive deep into the history or technical details right now—the general idea is simple and revolutionary: neuroplasticity is your brain's lifelong ability to reorganize itself by forming new neural connections, strengthening existing ones, and adapting to whatever you repeatedly experience or challenge it with. It's not a rudimentary object; it is a malleable and responsive nerve center—like clay that reshapes under pressure, getting stronger and more efficient the more you work it, but instead of simple clay, it is a whole organization working to keep you on your feet. When you consistently push through hard tasks every day, neuroplasticity kicks in and changes your brain in several powerful ways:

Builds the "mental muscle" in key areas: Regions like the anterior midcingulate cortex — the part that handles willpower and discomfort—grow stronger and less reactive, making future challenges feel less unbearable.

Releases growth factors (like BDNF, etc.): This protein acts like a steroid for your neurons, promoting more cell growth, stronger synapses, and better overall brain health.

Shifts your reward system: Dopamine (the "feel-good" chemical) starts flowing more from sustained effort and accomplishment rather than quick, easy distractions,

reducing cravings for dopamine-spiking habits and making the dopamine circuit more organized.

Adapts your stress response: Short-term discomfort trains your brain to handle stress better over time, lowering chronic anxiety and building true resilience.

Enhances emotional regulation and focus: The prefrontal cortex, or your "control center", gets a workout, improving self-control, decision-making, and the ability to see setbacks as growth opportunities.

These changes don't just improve your brain—they make you, as a person, better in tangible, life-changing ways: mentally tougher, calmer when the pressure hits, sharper at picking up any new skill, insanely persistent even when everything sucks, and ultimately capable of pulling off the burden that once felt impossible.

Just look at what happened to me—turning a humiliating 41% in chemistry into a 92% and becoming the top student. That wasn’t luck or some sort of cheating; It was deliberate discomfort forcing my brain to upgrade.

You're not stuck with the limited brain you have right now. You can—and should—enhance it every single day through hard, uncomfortable challenges.

And this isn’t some feel-good theory I made up. Researchers have proven it over and over by taking

completely ordinary people, throwing them way outside their comfort zones in real experiments, and measuring exactly how their brains changed. Some of the results shocked even the scientists running the studies.

Let's start with the one that hits closest to home for me: psychologist Carol Dweck's groundbreaking work on growth mindset. Across a series of famous experiments in the 1990s and 2000s, Dweck and her team deliberately put students and adults into brutally tough puzzles and problems—tasks designed to be way beyond their current abilities, guaranteeing frustration, mistakes, and failure. Participants were divided into groups: some were taught a "fixed mindset" (with praise focused on natural ability, such as "You're so smart"), while others were taught a "growth mindset" (with praise centered on effort, like "You worked really hard on that"). The growth-mindset group didn't endure the discomfort—they embraced it. They persisted longer, experimented with more strategies, found greater enjoyment in the challenge, and ultimately performed much better over time. Those with a fixed mindset gave up much faster, avoided risk, and plateaued. Later brain imaging studies connected to this work revealed real neuroplastic changes: engaging with difficult challenges strengthens circuits in the prefrontal cortex linked to resilience, transforming what feels like threatening failure into motivating opportunities for improvement.

Next, consider a more recent study on emotional discomfort by researchers Kaitlin Woolley and Ayelet Fishbach in 2022, conducted with students at Chicago's renowned Second City improv school. Hundreds of beginners—already anxious about performing—were split into groups. One group was directly instructed to seek out maximum awkwardness and unease during exercises, such as holding strange poses under observation or intentionally failing jokes. The other group simply aimed to "develop skills" without that framing. Unexpectedly, those who pursued discomfort didn't quit more often—they engaged more deeply, took greater risks, remained in the spotlight longer, and reported major increases in confidence and progress by the end. This demonstrates that deliberately seeking uncomfortable feelings speeds up neuroplasticity in brain regions related to motivation, risk-taking, and social confidence, making growth feel rewarding rather than punishing.

Then there's the famous London taxi driver study by Eleanor Maguire and colleagues, starting in 2000. Black-cab drivers in London must master "The Knowledge"—memorizing over 25,000 streets and thousands of landmarks through a brutal process that takes 2–4 years of constant study and repeated navigation failures. It is pure cognitive discomfort with high dropout rates. MRI scans revealed something remarkable: the longer drivers trained, the larger their posterior hippocampus became—a critical

region for spatial memory and navigation. Experienced cab drivers showed noticeably larger volumes in this area compared to novices or even bus drivers, who follow fixed routes with far less challenge. No such changes appeared in control groups. This is structural neuroplasticity at work: sustained, uncomfortable mental effort literally expands and restructures the brain for top level performance.

Ultimately, a simple yet powerful demonstration comes from Bogdan Draganski's 2004 juggling experiment. Beginners with no coordination experience were taught a basic threeball cascade and practiced daily for three months—expecting frequent drops, frustration, and awkwardness early on. Brain scans taken before and after showed increases in gray matter in regions responsible for visual motion processing and hand-eye coordination. When some participants stopped juggling, those newly developed brain structures began to shrink again. The meaning, frankly speaking from the bottom of my heart, is clear: Neuroplasticity might feel like torture at first—or even strangely cathartic—but it's really just a practice that demands consistency. Stick with it through the daily discomfort, and you'll forge a greater mind: one that makes sharper decisions, stays calmer under pressure, and carries the quiet, unshakable peace of truly great figures.

Together, these four experiments, from mindset challenges and improv awkwardness to taxi driver endurance and

juggling adaptations, demonstrate beyond doubt that daily difficult tasks do more than build character. They physically upgrade the brain. The frustration felt at the beginning is a signal that change is happening. If beginners in controlled studies can transform through conscious discomfort, imagine what controlled extreme challenges could do for you. >How to move this stone:

Now, you know exactly why choosing something uncomfortable every single day is one of the most powerful habits for building unbreakable character, relentless consistency, and a strong, resilient mind. It is, quite literally, what separates those who only dream about change from those who actually create it. But all the understanding in the world means nothing without action. This section is your practical guide to selecting the right task and staying consistent with it—without wasting excessive time or draining your energy.

Imagine waking up each morning with a clear sense of purpose, knowing that one deliberate choice will move you closer to the version of yourself you've always wanted to be. That's the quiet power of this practice. It doesn't demand hours of your day or heroic levels of motivation. It simply asks you to pick one thing that stretches you, do it, and let the momentum build. Over time, these small acts of courage and consistency compound into a life you're genuinely proud of.

+ STEP 1: How to Choose Your Daily Hard Task:

The operation begins with intentional selection. You don't need a long list—just one meaningful challenge each day would be sufficient to get enhanced.

Start by considering the main areas of your life where growth matters most to you:

- **Fitness and Physical Health**
- **Career or Skill Development**
- **Finances**
- **Relationship and Social Confidence**
- **Creativity or Personal Projects**
- **Mental and Emotional Resilience**

Choose the one for which you constantly make excuses and are not confident about when doing, that is often the exact place where the greatest progress is waiting.

From there, choose a task that creates real but manageable resistance. Examples might include:

- Going for a demanding run or working out when you'd rather stay in.

- Taking a full cold shower and staying under the water longer than feels comfortable.

- Having an honest, vulnerable conversation you've been putting off.

- Facing a fear directly, like speaking up in a meeting or reaching out to someone important.

Now, rate the difficulty on a simple 1-to-10 scale (1 being effortless, 10 being overwhelming). Aim for 6 to 8—challenging enough to feel significant, but realistic enough to complete. Make it specific and measurable: "Run 5 kilometers every single day" beats "exercise more."

Rotate across different areas throughout the week to keep things balanced and fresh. This prevents any single type of challenge from becoming routine too quickly.

+ STEP 2: The Backup Morning Ritual That Sets Everything in Motion:

Committing to a specific task may be challenging, and the most effective way to counter this is a morning reflection which lasts between 5 to 10 minutes. This small ritual is backed by solid research on habit formation.

A landmark study from University College London (published in the European Journal of Social Psychology in 2009, led by Phillippa Lally) examined how long it actually takes to form a habit. Researchers tracked 96 participants over 12 weeks as they worked to build new daily habits

(like eating a piece of fruit with lunch or going for a 15-minute run). Each day, participants recorded whether they performed their chosen behavior and how automatic it felt. The key finding: on average, it took 66 days for the behavior to become truly automatic, though it ranged from 18 to 254 days depending on the person and the complexity of the habit. More importantly, the study showed that consistency—even with occasional misses—mattered far more than perfection. Missing a day didn't derail progress as long as participants got back on track quickly.

This is why a quick daily reflection works so well. It keeps you intentional without requiring perfection.

Here is the exact structure used by me and thousands—if not millions—of others. Use a dedicated notebook, a journal, or even a simple note on your phone. Each page is divided into three straightforward sections:

- **Reflection:**

1) What did yesterday's task teach me?

(This builds self-awareness and helps you notice patterns in your growth)

- **Task Choice:**

2) Where am I feeling the most resistance today?

3) What one task, if completed, will make me proud tonight?

(Write the specific task right here)

- **Preparation & Tracking:**

4) What is one small step I can take right now to prepare?

(Examples: lay out running clothes, draft the first sentence of an email, block time on your calendar)

5) Did I complete today's task? (Yes/No) – mark at the end of the day.

Answering these four questions each morning (with one more to mark at the end of the day) takes very little time, yet it dramatically boosts your clarity, discipline, and overall consistency.

+ STEP 3: How to Follow Through Resistance:

Listen, this is the part where most people think they need some kind of superhuman willpower—and that's just not true, you don't. What you need is a couple of small, smart moves that make starting almost automatic and finishing feel like it is unavoidable.

The night before, do yourself a huge favor: set everything up. If tomorrow's task is a run, put your shoes and clothes

right by the bed or even by the door. If it's a tough conversation, draft the first couple of lines in a note on your phone or write down the main points you want to say. If it's deep work, clear your desk, close the tabs, and maybe even put your phone in another room. These little preparations aren't glamorous, but they remove that first wave of friction that usually stops people dead in their tracks. You wake up, see everything ready, and starting feels like the path of least resistance instead of the hardest thing in the world.

When the moment actually arrives and you feel that pull to delay—"I'll do it later," "I'm not feeling it right now"—don't argue with yourself. Don't try to pump yourself up with a big speech. Just count down from five. 5… 4… 3… 2… 1… and move. Stand up, put on the shoes, open the laptop, dial the number—whatever the first physical action is. That tiny countdown is magic because it hijacks the hesitation loop in your head and gets your body going before your mind has time to negotiate. I promise you, once you're in motion, the resistance drops way down. The first step is always the heaviest; the rest feels lighter.

While you're doing the thing, the discomfort is going to show up. That's not a sign something's wrong—that's the whole point. Your mind might complain, your body might be in pain, your emotions might try to pull you away, but that's okay. Let it all come. Don't fight the feeling or try to

push it down. Just notice it like it is weather passing through: “Yeah, this feels heavy right now. That’s fine. I expected this.” Keep going anyway. Breathe through it. Remind yourself that this moment is temporary, but the person you’re becoming by pushing through is permanent. Every minute you stay in it, you’re proving to yourself that you’re someone who follows through. That proof builds quietly, day after day, until one morning you wake up and realize you actually trust yourself now.

And when you finish—don’t just rush off to the next thing. Stop for ten seconds. Feel it. Let the relief and the quiet pride wash over you. Stand there, breathe, maybe smile a little. Say to yourself, “I did that. I really did.” That small pause is gold because it teaches your mind to associate finishing hard things with genuine satisfaction—not just relief, but real respect for yourself. Over time, that feeling becomes something you start to crave more than the comfort you used to chase.

Then go mark it down. Put that X on the calendar, check the box in your journal, whatever your system is. There’s something deeply satisfying about seeing those marks line up— proof in black and white that you’re becoming consistent. Protect that sequence. Not out of guilt, but because you know how good it feels to keep a promise to yourself.

+ Step 4: Handling Setbacks and Building Long-Term Momentum:

The truth nobody likes to say out loud: you're going to miss days. Life gets messy. You'll be sick, exhausted, traveling, or just have one of those days where everything goes sideways, and when it happens, you might be tempted by your own voice that you're back to square one, that you might as well give up. Don't listen to it.

Missing one day—or even a few—doesn't perish the progress you've made. What matters is what you do next. Give yourself permission to be human, take a breath, and simply restart tomorrow. No dramatic comeback speech needed. Just open your journal, answer the questions again, pick the next task, and go. The sequence might have a gap, but you start a new one right away. Consistency isn't about never breaking the streak—it is about never staying broken.

If you notice that you are missing more often than feels good, use it as information, not as ammunition against yourself. Look back gently: Were the tasks too big? Was the timing off? Did you forget to prep the night before? Make one small adjustment and keep moving. Sometimes lowering the bar for a day or two—choosing a slightly easier version of the task—actually helps you get back on track faster than forcing something huge.

As the weeks turn into months, something beautiful starts to happen. The tasks that used to feel heavy begin to feel more manageable. You'll catch yourself handling things that would have scared you before without thinking twice. That's when you know it is time to raise the bar a little. Extend the time, add intensity, layer in a second small challenge— whatever feels like the natural next step. Do it gradually, the way you'd add weight in the gym. You want progress that sticks, not a burnout crash.

Every couple of weeks, take ten quiet minutes to flip back through your journal. Read what you wrote on the harder days. Notice the patterns—what kinds of tasks light you up, where you've grown the most, how your answers to "What did yesterday teach me?" have changed. Celebrate it. Not with huge rewards such as beverages, but with real acknowledgment: "Look how far I've come. I'm actually doing this." That reflection isn't just nice—it is fuel. It reminds you why you started and shows you, in your own handwriting, that this is working.

And if you ever want an extra layer of support, bring someone else in. Tell a close friend, a partner. There's something powerful about saying it out loud and knowing someone's rooting for you. It doesn't have to be complicated—just a quick message like "I showered with crystal cold water for 10 days straight ". Believe me, if they are truly your friends, they will congratulate you, offer some tips, or—at the very least—show genuine pride in what you've accomplished.

This isn't about turning into a machine. It is about becoming someone who trusts themselves, who knows they can handle hard things, who looks back at the end of the year and feels proud of who they've become. And it starts with one morning, one task, one choice to follow through.

I'm telling you this because I genuinely want it for you. That quiet confidence, that deep self-respect—it is waiting on the other side of these small daily decisions. You've already taken the hardest step: deciding you want more for yourself. Now just keep going, one day at a time. Believe in yourself.

The End to the Chapter

This chapter started in an unlikely place: my own chemistry class back in school. I dreaded it, avoided it because it felt pointless, confusing, and outside my comfort zone. Little did I know that years later I'd be borrowing the word "chemistry" for something completely different: the internal reaction that happens when someone consistently chooses to do hard, uncomfortable things day after day.

What began as a personal frustration with a subject, which I couldn't stand, has turned into one of the clearest lessons I've ever learned. Real change isn't about waiting for motivation, perfect plans, or some dramatic turning point. It's about creating a small daily reaction—one task, one moment of pushing past resistance—that keeps happening over and over until the compound effect takes over.

Everything laid out in these pages is built on that idea: The short morning questions; The honest look at where resistance is strongest; The single task chosen and completed; and the mark in the journal at the end of the day. None of it is complicated or time-consuming, yet kept up consistently, it produces a shift that's hard to describe until it's felt.

The tasks don't have to be huge. The streak doesn't have to be perfect. What matters is consistency, returning to the process tomorrow and the day after—and the day after that. Over time, the accumulated days start speaking for themselves: greater calm under pressure, deeper self-trust, fewer moments of regret over what wasn't done.

All the tools needed are already within your reach: a notebook, a few minutes each morning, and the willingness to choose growth whenever the opportunity arises

A Healthy Mind

HOW TO RECOVER

SO THAT YOU DO NOT FEEL BEHIND

How to Recover (So That You Don't Feel Behind)

After a tough gym session, Bob comes home late, thinking that he will rest now—but how? What will Bob do as a recovery? The main question is this, and now I am going to help you to resolve this question in a way that will assist you to manage the workload—even if you have an extreme workload throughout your work period.

Personal Share

I wanted more. In fact, I wanted to be the best in every single field in the world so badly that I even compared myself to Shah Ismail Khatai, the emperor of the Safavid Empire who became king at fourteen. But no matter how much I pushed, I wasn't growing at all—my peers kept getting better and better, while I always felt like I was falling behind. That's when I decided to work even harder, so hard that I had time to eat only once a day and fill every minute with training, studying, or practice.

Just one week into this new routine my body started breaking down—I'd wake up sore as hell, unable to move for the first ten seconds, feeling completely paralyzed. On top of that, a sharp pain tore through my knee every time I moved, so I finally went to the doctor. He looked at me,

straight into the eyes, and said I couldn't do any physical activity for at least three months. I was shocked; this was the first time a doctor had ever told me my health was in trouble, especially when I thought I was pouring everything into staying strong. But I didn't listen—I ignored him completely and pushed even harder, convinced that if I just kept going, I'd conquer everything.

Soon, the damage went deeper than my knee. I stopped wanting to talk to anyone, I'd sit in one spot staring blankly at the wall, not thinking, not feeling, just empty. People around me thought I was depressed or going through some internal crisis, but it wasn't that—I was on full autopilot, watching myself from the outside like I was in third person mode with no control over my body or mind. That's when it finally hit me: I had to break this cycle before it broke me completely.

So, I eased up—I started waking up at 6:30 instead of 5 a.m., trained only four times a week instead of every day, and limited my studying to five focused hours without piling on extra schoolwork.

In addition to that, I started reading and researching the recovery process, and I found some powerful actions that helped me rebuild my momentum and get back on my feet.

After just two weeks of sticking to this new balanced approach, I leveled up completely—I started thinking clearer than ever and felt like water: flexible, flowing, free of any pain or sickness.

And the key thing is, I scheduled that recovery time for the evenings, right after wrapping up all my daily tasks, and it made a huge difference in helping me bounce back stronger. That rest time turned into a genuine treat—something I looked forward to—and placing it at the end of the day finally let me exhale and recharge properly and efficiently.

What is The Evening Treat?

An evening treat sounds like something that every human being would enjoy. And that is what you would enjoy purely with your heart for 15 to up to 45 minutes, as more than that is contributing to weakening your soul by deceiving you that you deserve more recharging—be strict to this rule.

Additionally, this should make you feel good and shouldn't necessarily be productive; if you prefer to do something productive instead (that also makes you comfortable) then do it—if it makes you yourself.

Now, if you normally enjoy an activity which isn't really bringing that peace into your soul and your mind, you should change yourself. And by that, I mean your mind

should want to be in placid; for that to happen, as we already discussed, you should do mindfulness to be aware of yourself and your surroundings.

There are lots of different activities for this period of your day, as an example here are some:

- **Long hot bath or shower**
- **Comfort TV show or movie**
- **Lying outside, looking at the sky**



Yes, these are examples, and while some might seem bizarre, it doesn’t mean that you must do them; You do what makes you rest, what makes you feel like you are flying through the thin air.

The Science Behind

Scientifically speaking, evening rest helps your brain convert the day's experiences into lasting memories by giving it quiet time to replay and strengthen important neural connections without new information competing for attention.

When you stop scrolling, working, or engaging with intense stimuli in the evening, your brain shifts from "input mode" to "processing mode", organizing the mental clutter of the day into stable, retrievable knowledge. Research shows that even 10-30 minutes of quiet rest with minimal sensory input can boost memory retention as effectively as a short nap, because your brain opportunistically consolidates learning whenever conditions allow, not just during sleep.

This "golden window" before bed is particularly valuable because it protects what you learned from being overwritten by new distractions, helps strip intense emotions from difficult experiences while keeping the facts, and often sparks creative insights or problem-solving breakthroughs that active thinking couldn't achieve.

How to choose a treat if you are perplexed

A “treat” isn’t just anything which sounds enjoyable. It’s something that actually restores your energy. The tricky part is that what sounds relaxing isn’t always what works. That’s why you should view choosing the right treat as an experiment and not as a decision you make once and stick to forever.

+ Start With an Experiment Phase:

Pick one option and try it consistently for a week. This could be some activities such as going on a short walk, drawing, playing an instrument, stretching, gaming, reading fiction, or simply doing nothing. After each session, notice how you feel and note it down clearly. Do you feel calmer? More grounded? Or strangely tired and restless? At the end of the week, reflect honestly. Keep what restores you, drop what doesn’t, and test something new the next week. Over time, you’ll build a personal list of treats that genuinely refill your energy rather than drain it.

+ Ordinary Mistakes:

One of the most common mistakes is “productive” relaxation. Podcasts, audiobooks, or videos that “feel” like self-improvement. These can be great as a recharge, but they still require some input. If your brain is already overloaded, they may prevent real rest.

The second trap is letting your treat turn into mindless scrolling. What starts as “five minutes to relax” can easily become forty minutes of mindless action that leaves you even more drained than before.

A third mistake, as mentioned before, is guilt. Many people feel like they need to earn rest, or that enjoying themselves is irresponsible. That guilt can cancel out the benefit of the treat itself and can leave you with a defeated mindset. If you must have a rest, then you must take it. No. Matter. What.

+ How to Do It Easily:

Primarily, schedule it like you normally schedule your “priority tasks”. Put it on your calendar or write it in your notes so that you don’t push it aside as “non-urgent”.

Secondly, set a timer for it. This helps in two ways: it prevents your treat from overrunning into time you need for other things, and it reassures your mind that you’re not losing control over your schedule.

Thirdly, use environment cues to signal that this time is different. Put your phone on Do Not Disturb right after the timer is alarmed. Dim the lights and sit in a specific chair.

These cues train your brain to shift into rest mode faster, so you don’t waste half your treat time just trying to unwind.

Remember, the worst days deserve the best recovery, but that doesn't mean that you should spend your days, thinking that each day was the worst day ever.

The effect on you

The long-term effects of this are countless; because if you do implement this, you will literally be limitless. You will become a type of person who is always present—not in the future nor in the past.

To be able to stick to the tasks, you need to be disciplined, but to be able to continue for the rest of your life you need timed, premeditated recharge.

Implement Now

So now, you're going to make a room in your day for rest, and remember, the duration should be less than an hour. Also, treat it like the urgent tasks in your routine. Don't even dare to skip this, thinking it is not vital—it is.

A Healthy Mind

VISUALIZATION

Visualization

In this chapter, we will examine a mental habit often confused with mindfulness, yet operating through a different cognitive mechanism. Before adopting this practice, my performance followed a paradoxical pattern: subjectively, I felt focused and prepared, but objectively, the outcomes failed to reflect that state.

Over time, I reached four finals without this habit integrated into my routine. Each time, I entered confident and motivated—and each time, I lost. The repeated mismatch between perceived readiness and actual performance produced mounting frustration, a predictable response when effort, expectation, and outcome diverge.

After the final loss, I began researching why this discrepancy occurs and how high-level performers reliably translate mental readiness into operation. This inquiry led me to visualization, a technique extensively discussed within performance psychology and cognitive science.

After approximately two weeks of consistent use, noticeable changes emerged in my performance. I reached two back-to-back finals and won both. While anecdotal, the shift was enough to justify closer analysis-not as motivation, but as mechanism.

This chapter treats visualization as a form of mental simulation. We will examine how it transforms attention,

expectation, and action readiness, and why it can meaningfully influence performance outcomes.

What is Visualization?

Visualization is the practice of forming clear mental images with your eyes closed. It encourages you to be more successful.

When you picture yourself writing an exam with ease, or facing your fears with courage, you begin to experience it before you really feel it. You feel what you would feel, think what you would think, and understand whether you truly want it and how much. You taste victory before you get it. That taste becomes the drive that pushes you to get to work and to simply do it. At the end of the day, you become a winner mentally. If you succeed, you know you followed the plan and executed it well. If something goes wrong, you gain clarity about what still needs work. In both cases, you leave stronger than before, and that is what makes this practice truly enhancing.

This practice is not new. It has ancient roots in Greek philosophy, where the Cyrenaic school— founded in the 4th century BC—originated a technique known as the premeditation of future evils (futurorum malorum præmeditatio). This involved deliberately visualizing potential hardships and setbacks in advance to reduce

their emotional impact when they occurred, building mental toughness and resilience.

The practice was later adopted and refined by the Stoic philosophers, such as Seneca in the 1st century AD, who used it to prepare the mind for life's uncertainties and cultivate emotional steadiness.

Today, modern neuroscience supports this ancient wisdom. fMRI (functional magnetic resonance imaging) studies show that visualizing a practice activates many of the same neural pathways as performing it in reality, suggesting that this method was not only philosophical, but neurologically beneficial.

The practice, as we can clearly see, has some mind-blowing results, meaning doing it is not a time wasted.

How Visualization shapes the mind

Visualization is the deliberate mental rehearsal of an experience, action, or an outcome using imagination as if it were happening in real time. While doing this activity, you feel as though you are dreaming—almost as if you are literally in space. Your brain is actively planning and rehearsing what you would do in the scenario you are visualizing. As mentioned earlier, the brain activates the same neurons that would be triggered in the real situation. At the same time, it engages the motor cortex, which helps

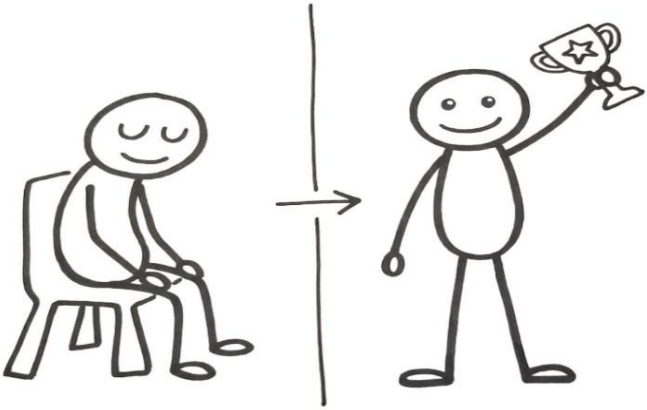
plan movement, and hippocampus and temporal lobe, which are involved in memory retrieval.

What makes visualization truly powerful is not the moment of the process of it, but rather what happens after repetition. Each time you vividly imagine an action, your brain strengthens the neural pathways associated with that experience. Over time, these pathways become more efficient, more automatic—just like muscle memory. The mind does not sharply distinguish between repeated imagination and repeated reality; it simply adapts to what it encounters most often (That is why you should prioritize this action). Ultimately, situations that once felt unfamiliar or intimidating begin to feel known, even expected. Visualization trains the brain to treat success, calmness, and control as familiar states rather than distant possibilities.

When you mentally rehearse a scenario, you are also rehearsing your emotional response to it. Fear, uncertainty, and hesitation gradually lose their influence as the brain learns that the situation is not a peril. This emotional conditioning is subtle but profound. Instead of reacting with panic or self-doubt, the mind begins to respond with steadiness and clarity. In moments that once triggered stress, the nervous system recognizes familiarity and remains calm. Visualization, when practiced consistently, teaches the mind that it is safe to stay

composed under pressure, no matter if the pressure is constant or not.

The most overlooked effect of visualization is its impact on identity. The brain updates its internal image of who you are based on what you repeatedly experience non-stop - even if the experience was imagined. When you visualize yourself acting with confidence, focus, and intention, the mind begins to accept that version of you as ordinary. This quiet shift in self-perception changes behavior naturally, without much force. You stop “trying to be confident” and instead act from a place where confidence feels expected.



Visualization works not because it convinces you for a while, but because it reshapes the whole mental model of who you believe yourself to be.

How To Perform

Visualization, even though it has this many benefits, isn't that hard to perform. In fact, the hardest part of this act, as for every other, is the consistency- to do it even if you feel like a corpse.

The first step of visualization is to find a quiet environment in which to practice. Remember, doing it in a busy environment will result in nothing but a loss of time. The second step is to close your eyes and imagine yourself performing the action you want to accomplish, without failing, and with everything going as you wish. The third step is to stay focused. Do not allow your mind to drift to unrelated thoughts, such as what you will eat later. Instead, fully immerse yourself in that moment. Channel all of your intention and determination into the practice and the image you are creating.

For visualization to shape the mind effectively, it must be intentional and immersive. Always visualize from a first-person perspective, as if you are inside the experience rather than watching it from the outside. Engage movement, emotion, and environment—feel your posture, hear the sounds, sense the atmosphere. Keep sessions

short but vivid; even two or three focused minutes can be enough when done consistently. Visualization is not about fantasy or wishful thinking—it is mental training. And like any form of training, its power comes from clarity, repetition, and presence.

As you can see, practicing visualization is not as baffling as it may seem, since it involves only the steps mentioned earlier—but that does not mean it will be effortless. You may struggle with focus at first, and if that happens, continue anyway. It can also help to reduce time spent on social media and other dopamine-spiking activities, as they often contribute to this difficulty. In the end, understand that visualization is simple to practice and has the power to make a positive, lasting impact on your life.

A Healthy Mind

THE OTHER POLICIES

The Other Policies

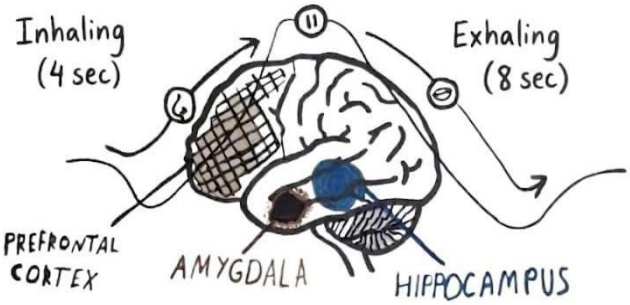
Other Policies, though not central, still have the potential to create profound improvement. These policies (or rules), even though they are not the habits you do every day, take their time and give you a feeling of getting better—in a relaxed way. Overall, I mean that even though these may seem small and simple activities, they lead to a great deal of outcome after implementation. I'm sure you won't regret these, as I and millions of others haven't.

Deep Breathing

Deep breathing is the smallest deliberate act that rewrites the brain. One slow inhale through the nose stretches the lungs just enough to quiet the locus coeruleus (the part of your brain responsible for triggering your stress and anxiety response.), the tiny brainstem node that releases noradrenaline—your brain's stress chemical—every time you feel pressed; a long exhale lets CO_2 fall, reduces amygdala reactivity and hands the steering wheel back to the prefrontal cortex. In the space of six seconds, you have shifted from the jagged beta rhythm of alert stress to the wide-angle alpha—theta band where memories are tagged and creativity sparks.

The first hard evidence that this is more than folklore came in 2016 when a Nature team asked volunteers to learn a tricky finger-tapping sequence and then sit still for half an hour breathing at five breaths a minute. The slow-breath group still played the sequence 56 % better the next day while fMRI showed their hippocampus glowing like a forge; the control group, breathing normally, had already started to forget. Daily repetitions of the same micro-task thicken gray matter in the hippocampus and anterior cingulate, the seats of memory and emotional control, while the vagus nerve releases acetylcholine that slows the heart and lifts heart-rate variability, the biometric of resilience. Within minutes, measurable shifts in heart-rate variability and stress markers begin. Some studies suggest that slow breathing may influence neurotransmitter systems, including serotonin and dopamine pathways, and working-memory scores on n-back tasks beat those achieved by the same people after a brisk walk.

Yogis have paced three-part breaths for millennia, but the West only clocked the mechanism in 1986 when Jack Feldman identified the preBötzinger complex, the brainstem metronome that translates rhythm into feeling; his 2025 follow-up showed mice trained to breathe slowly lost their learned fear entirely, proof that the link is evolutionary, not mystical.





For the reader, the recipe is simple: sit tall, inhale through the nose for four counts while the belly rises, hold for seven, exhale through pursed lips for eight while the belly falls, repeat five cycles—ninety seconds that reboot the operating system you live in.

Stretching

A single luxurious stretch while you are still half inside the dream does more for the mind than most gadgets sold for that purpose. The moment you open your eyes the brain is

washed in a pulse of cortisol meant to kick the body into motion; if you stay supine and let the arms drift over the head, the ribs lift and the diaphragm drops, the vagus nerve picks up the change and answers with acetylcholine that flattens the cortisol curve before it has a chance to spike. You have just given yourself a softer landing into waking life.

The spine, folded for seven or eight hours, craves micromovement the way dry soil craves water. A gentle reclined twist—knees fallen to one side, arms spread like wings—lifts each vertebra apart by millimeters, drawing fresh cerebrospinal fluid into the discs and flushing the overnight metabolic grit away from the neural roots. MRI studies show that even a thirty-second decompression widens the intervertebral spaces enough to improve proprioceptive signaling to the cerebellum, sharpening balance and reaction time for the rest of the day. The brain receives clearer postcards from the body and, in return, lowers background muscle tone, so you stand taller without trying.

Before sleep, the same rule applies in reverse. Lying on your back, sliding one heel at a time down the sheet until the leg fully lengthened, then bringing the knee toward the chest and circling the ankle, tells the parasympathetic system that the saber-toothed project deadline has been left outside the bedroom. Heart-rate variability climbs within two minutes, and the prefrontal cortex, now freed

from guarding the upright posture, begins the long wave of theta activity that stitches the day's fragments into memory. You do not need a mat, a timer, or fifteen disciplined minutes; three slow reaches in each direction while the lamp is still dim are enough to reset the central nervous system from alert to repair.

The beauty of the reclined stretch is that it happens in the borderland between sleep and wake where willpower is still unnecessary. The body remembers the motion from infancy, when waking always began with arms flung wide and a yawn that curved the spine like a drawn bow. Reenacting that miniature arc each morning and night keeps the mind supple because it keeps the body honest: if the soft tissues are free, the brain interprets safety; if the spine glides, thoughts glide. One vertebra, one breath, one moment of lengthening is all the negotiation required between the night you leave behind and the day you are about to enter.

Looking at emptiness

Modern research shows that the gaps between work matter just as much as the work itself, especially when those gaps last only seconds rather than minutes. Common advice has always pushed for long rest periods—fifteen-minute coffee breaks, hour-long lunches, full nights of sleep—to recharge the brain. But new studies looking at very short pauses show that recovery starts almost

immediately when you stop focusing on a task, with real benefits showing up within seconds of putting down the mental effort.

A key study from 1989 by Henning and colleagues watched data-entry workers who naturally took tiny breaks averaging just 27.4 seconds during their work, with some pauses as short as eight seconds and others up to three minutes. The researchers found that these short stops strongly predicted lower heart rates and fewer mistakes when the workers started typing again. This challenges what we assume about rest, suggesting that the nervous system needs far less downtime than we thought to start healing itself.

The brain processes these brief stops in surprising ways. Scientists at the National Institutes of Health used brain scanning to watch people learning new skills and found that leaving ten-second gaps between practice sessions let the brain replay what was learned at twenty times the normal speed. People who took these tiny breaks, often just closing their eyes or staring at one spot, remembered four times better than those who practiced without stopping. The brain uses these short pauses not as empty time but rather as important processing windows, turning fresh memories into lasting ones without any extra work.

This method works for tired eyes too. The well-known 20-20-20 rule suggests looking at something twenty feet away

for twenty seconds every twenty minutes. By focusing on a distant wall or the horizon, the eye muscles that squeeze to see close up finally relax, and blinking returns to normal. You might think such short breaks could not possibly help after hours of screen time, but research shows they really do reduce dry eyes and keep attention sharp during long work periods.

Putting this into practice means changing how we think about deep work, realizing that top performance comes from switching between focus and brief release rather than pushing through for hours. Recent studies in schools found that adding ninety-second breaks every ten minutes—less than two minutes of interruption total—greatly reduces the attention loss that normally happens during long classes. You can try this by letting your eyes rest on a blank wall or closing them completely, giving your visual processing a short holiday that lets your brain reset. Rather than seeing these moments as wasted time, understanding them as necessary brain maintenance changes how you structure your work, allowing you to stay sharp without the tiredness that usually builds up during long mentally-draining tasks.

Believe that you are before you are

This is what differentiates the good from the great. Thinking, acting, believing that you are already a millionaire; that you already did get into that college; that

you already did get into the first team is the drive and why you will get to that point, eventually. If you want to taste that success, you must implement this into your daily life. There is even a scientific study, which backs my point; In 1979, Harvard psychologist Ellen Langer ran a famous experiment with elderly men in their seventies and eighties. She put them in a retreat for one week where one group had to live as if it were 1959—pretending they had already succeeded in being twenty years younger. They spoke about that time in present tense, used only 1959 technology, and did daily activities as if they were really living back then. The other group just talked about the past without this "as if" approach.

After just one week, the men who acted like they had already reached their goal showed dramatic physical improvements compared to the other group. Their joints became more flexible, their grip strength improved, and their hearing and vision got sharper. Independent observers said they looked noticeably younger in photos taken after the study. Their intelligence test scores improved by 63 percent, while the other group only improved by 44 percent.

The study showed that adopting the mindset of someone who has already succeeded— living "as if" you have already reached your goal—creates real physical changes within days. Their bodies reacted to the mental shift as if the imagined reality were true, effectively speeding up the

very results they were pretending to have already achieved. And that doesn't just work for the elderly or for men—it can work with you this way (might even be better) too, if you just allow this to penetrate into your daily routine.

Gratitude practicing

This habit—even though it might look mentally draining (but it's not, indeed)—will be the one which will build your character.

As Marcus Aurelius meant, your thoughts should only be the type of thoughts which you can tell anyone without any hesitation: they should be pure and with good meaning and desires. This habit, therefore, will be the first and primary activity which will lead you to this type of critical thinking, as well as everyday thinking. It involves writing on a note 3-10 things you are grateful for every day, or you can just try to see everything from a better perspective. Someone walks slowly in front of you—maybe they have an injury which prevents him from walking; someone bumps into you—maybe they are in a hurry to somewhere important; someone has trouble with talking—maybe he has brain fog or had a hard day the day before. Think of the better, even though it might not be. That's how you are going to develop full control over your own subconscious.

Positive psychology founder Martin Seligman discovered that happiness could be reliably increased through

gratitude practice. After his research revealed that individuals who wrote down three good things each day for one week were happier for the following six months (longer than most psychiatric drugs), he investigated how gratitude could override hedonic adaptation, or our brains' ability to always want more once we get what we desire. Seligman found that gratitude can retrain your brain to see what you have instead of what you don't.

To start these habits properly, the first rule is that you don’t need to rush; start small and slow. Try to flow into that habit so that it feels natural—this is the goal.

A Healthy Mind

SO, WHAT NOW?

So, What Now?

Now, after everything we have talked about—from that we make a very small fraction of the history of this earth and still achieved and became more superior to animals which thrived before us for millions of years to the practice of gratitude—everything is left upon you. The very same passion for change that lives in us for several millennia is yours to its full capacity, but the thing is—will you actually change? After everything written in this book, which is vital for change, the question is will you use these piles of data in order for you to achieve success in your own mind and over your own mind?

So, now, you are going to place these habits in your schedule—even adding just one might change your life—and do that activity as said in this book and as you (maybe) wrote in your notes. That's where transformation begins. Nobody cares about you as much as you do.

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Most people go through life never truly experiencing the true inner peace and never reaching their peak mental strength that they were meant to acquire.

A Healthy Mind explores the science and philosophy behind mental strength, tracing the history of neuroscience to reveal how the brain shapes who we are and how we can reshape it. Through practical exercises (including mindfulness and neuroplasticity techniques), this book guides you toward confidence, and genuine inner peace.

Your mind is your power—learn to use it.

Omar Garagozov is a writer and neuroscience researcher based in Baku, Azerbaijan. A Healthy Mind is his first book.